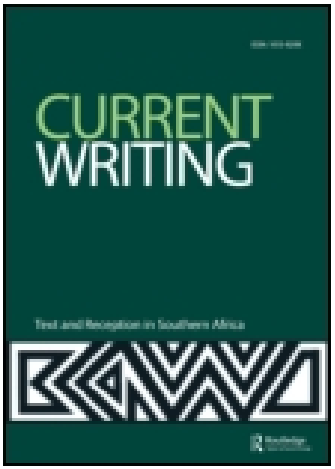
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"Different people just have different minds": A personal attempt to understand Ju/'hoan storytelling aesthetics

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"Different People Just Have Different Minds": A Personal Attempt to Understand Ju/'hoan Storytelling Aesthetics

Megan Biesele

> Of course, some people tell stories one way, some another. Perhaps it is because people sometimes separate for a while and still go on telling stories. But all these stories about the old times — people use different words and names for the same things. There are many different ways to talk. Different people just have different minds.
>
> !Unn/obe Morethlwa (A Ju/'hoan Woman) — Kauri, Botswana, 1971.

This sixty year old Ju/'hoan storyteller had a way of putting things. !Unn/obe, whom I met in Botswana when I was twenty-five, favoured comic dialogue and landscape description above all else in her tales — except perhaps the creation of social shock. Other storytellers, I had already seen, favoured and excelled in other devices. The result was that in Ju/'hoan culture there seemed to be as many ways to tell a traditional story as there were storytellers. I was dazzled — but confused.

I asked !Unn/obe about the coexistence in Ju/'hoan tradition of many versions of 'the same' tale. She was unfazed. Her answer (above) contained as much about variability in storytelling aesthetics as about plots and storylines. She accompanied the answer with an eloquent shrug. I remember that shrug was the first glimpse for me of the elaborate tolerance I was coming to see in her egalitarian society. The Ju/'hoan hunting and gathering ethos, it seemed, gave wide latitude not only for variation in daily behaviour but also for the expressive styles of different individuals.

Some of the variations I saw and heard in expressive style were downright flamboyant. //Xukxa N!a'an, a crony of !Unn/obe's who lived about a hundred miles away, was fond of using comical reduplication in her stories to emphasise instances of outrageousness. For her, arguing people did not merely *n≠uiankhoe*,

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contradict each other, but *n≠uin-n≠uiankhoe*; gnawings made by a rabbit on the moon's face were */'om/'omsi*, "gnaw-gnawings"; dirty-minded speech was "foul-foul" or */kau-/kau*; vultures could drop *//aba-//aba*, voraciously and scandalously, out of the sky onto corpses; people could "kill-kill" each other, *!hun-!hun*. A man about her age living in the same camp liked to wave his hands in emphasis while prolonging the glottal stop in the word */'hom* (beautiful) to show how a woman could be lovely beyond description.

Bemused, I began to wonder about the relationship between storytelling style and its content or message. If the medium was the message ... might personal ostentations in style liberate a tradition from slavish adherence to content, yet somehow preserve that content in its essentials? I began to ask whether culture was perhaps a less 'monolithic' concept than I had thought: whether individual expressive energies are in fact what combine to make a culture. The concept of dialogue within a tradition *itself* constituting the tradition began to stir for me.

This was more than twenty years ago. In this article I want to illustrate the process by which !Unn/obe, //Xukxa, and other Ju/'hoan storytellers further clarified my thinking as I recorded their tales and tried to understand whether and how the tales informed their lives. I'll start with an excerpt from one of !Unn/obe's stories, and eventually move on to a story from a Ju/'hoan man I worked with in Namibia many years later. For both of them I shall try to show how their life experiences and personalities influenced their art. In a deeper sense, as well, I want to show how I discovered that the life stories and folktales told by these storytellers both reflected and called into being their contemporary Ju/'hoan culture.

In the story from which the first excerpt is taken, the elephant girl is the heroine. Her mother has been murdered by the elephant girl's own husband, in retaliation for an insult he wasn't supposed to have heard. The elephant girl has retaliated by murdering her husband. She is now travelling unwillingly with her husband's younger brothers (who are clearly bent on vengeance) to the camp of her in-laws. She has been given a magical gemsbok horn by her grandmother, to blow upon in time of need:

> The elephant girl packed up her things and her grandmother helped her. The old woman fixed her up and got her things ready. "The child will stay with us but you will go", she said. The brothers agreed, and so they left. As they were walking to the other camp, the elephant girl kept asking them how far it was to the next hill. Sometimes they would be travelling along a valley of soft sand and sometimes they came to a hill. They would answer

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her, and tell her how far it was. She said, "Tell me how the hills lie, tell me how far it is between them. And when we get near the hill near your camp, let me know. I want to stop before we come into the camp."

They continued to walk. She asked them again about the hills that lay between them and the village. They said, "Here is one hill. Beyond it lies a valley of soft sand and then another hill and then another valley. Then there's another hill, another valley, and then comes a hill that lies green.

"Near the green hill is our camp. You'll see huts, and children running about with clean tummies and playing. That's our camp."

She said, "All right", and remembered what they had said.

They came to a hill and she asked, "Is this it?"

"No, it's still far ahead", they said.

"All right, then we'll keep going", she answered.

A while later she said, "Is it this one?"

"No", they said, "that's the wrong hill."

They walked and walked and when they got to the green hill she asked, "This one?"

"This is the hill next to our village", they answered.

She looked, and there were children standing about in the camp with clean tummies. "Yau!" she said, "now you two go on in. I'm going to powder myself and then come into the camp." The brothers went into the camp ahead of her. The elephant girl took out the gemsbok horn and blew it. She blew down the brothers and blew down their people, and the camps of their people were simply flattened. She flattened them all and left them lying there just as her grandmother had told her to do ....

!Unn/obe used several idiosyncratic devices of dialogue and description in this story to emphasise the startling nature of events in the plot. Among them was the reinforcement, using two different dialogue approaches, of the dramatic progression through the dry landscape to the green hill. The events themselves are shocking both to the outside reader and in the context of the actual social world of the Ju/'hoansi, who prize harmony and work hard to prevent familial violence. However, the events as imaginary story elements were extremely familiar to !Unn/obe's listeners. The same plot had been fleshed out time and time again by different storytellers, each using different devices, as !Unn/obe did, to make the narration both strange and familiar with each new telling.

Some versions I heard in both Botswana and Namibia elaborate on the beauty and the virtuous nature of the heroine, describing in great detail her demeanour, clothing, and ornaments. !Unn/obe's version emphasises dialogue between the heroine and her enemies, euphemisms of trickery as she "powders or freshens

herself up" and transforms this social ritual into magical vengeance, and the incremental description of landscape for plot advancement.

Other versions emphasise other dramatic devices. For comparison, here is a version of 'the same' vengeance episode that //Xukxa N!a'an told at Dobe, Botswana, also in 1971:

> One day her husband's younger brothers made a new plan. "Let's *marry* her this time — come on!" [In this context "marry" could be a euphemism for sexual intercourse in general.] They said to each other, "Let's not talk any more about killing her, because she's so very beautiful. Such a person you don't kill — you marry her instead."
>
> But one of the brothers disagreed. "Yau! She's beautiful, but was our older brother ugly? He was beautiful too, and she killed him: why do you say we shouldn't kill her but should marry her instead?"
>
> The brothers argued back and forth. "Let's marry her!", "No: let's kill her!" they shouted to each other. But finally they decided to marry her. So they all left their camp and went to get her. There were many of them, and they brought her home to their camp.
>
> When they arrived at the camp, she took out her medicine horn, the kind that kills people. Then she blew: "N!a-a-a-a! What do you think you're doing, yau? First you want to kill me and now you want to marry me? What kind of marriage did you have in mind? If this is what you're going to do, I'll see that all of you die! Not a one of you shall have me!"
>
> And that's just what happened. With her magical horn, she flattened them all. Every one of the brothers died. They were finished, dead, and did not come back to life again. She went home to her own camp. Now you've seen what things were like in the long-ago time.

Here we have lifelike and somewhat comical dialogue, too, but it hints at the larger metaphorical issues involved. It is not stated, first, whether the brothers meant for one of them or all of them to 'marry' her. It is often the case that a younger brother will marry an older brother's widow. But there is also a pervasive joke about sharing women and sharing 'meat' in Ju/'hoan culture: although marriage is meant to be exclusive, such joking acts as a kind of 'safety valve' just as mother-in-law jokes do in American culture.

Many metaphorical clues, as I explained in my book *Women Like Meat: The Folklore and Foraging Ideology of the Kalahari Ju/'hoan* (1993), tie Ju/'hoan women as sexual objects to women as meat animals. Though as //Xukxa told it there was no direct address by the men to the elephant girl, she 'heard' them and knew perfectly well what they meant by their *double entendre*. Yet in her hunting-gathering culture this equation is not pejorative: Ju/'hoan men give immense honour to meat animals just as they do to women. In the story, her

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imagined rejection of this joking equation, and her assertion of her independence and 'equal and opposite' strength, are the plot-moving devices which //Kukxa was most interested in exploring.

Twenty years later in 1991, the linguist Patrick Dickens and I were working in Namibia on Ju/'hoan vocabulary for a new orthography and dictionary of the language. Patrick collected a version of this 'same' episode from /Kunta Boo, a male storyteller of approximately the same age as !Unn/obe had been when I worked with her in Namibia. In his story, the heroine has been reconstituted by her grandmother after being killed by her husband's brothers, one of whom has in the meantime taken her as a wife:

> One day the two men who had killed her saw her living with her grandmother. They talked to the old woman and one of them became betrothed to the daughter and then married her.
>
> Many years later she was travelling with the two men. They were moving villages to the red mountain. On the way the woman said, "You two go on ahead, I must just go and relieve myself". She went into the veld a little way, and she took out her horn and blew powerfully on it, and it cried out, "may you two vulture arses die!" There and then the two men collapsed and died. And the woman went back to her grandmother and continued to live with her.

In this episode, yet another twist on the theme of vengeance and distrust between in-laws appears. Here there is delayed retribution, and another touch on the theme of women-as-meat (from the woman's point of view this time, as the men are likened to filthy parts of scavenging birds). The male storyteller seems to have emphasised this vivid female outspokenness in clear contrast to the emphasis on quiet, deceptive virtue by the two women storytellers. Yet the basic themes are the same here as in the above versions. They will be well-known to all, and provide the well of reference from which all versions ultimately take their power. The storytellers' twists on the plot never violate these themes, but rather explore their ramifications, turning them over and over in a sort of fascination to see how many intellectual changes may be rung on 'the same' theme and plot.

It is difficult to convey without multiplying further examples the richly individualistic nature of Ju/'hoan tradition. When I was first in the field collecting tales, I was overwhelmed by this richness and even, at times, apparent contradiction. I floundered in my work of understanding the tradition as a whole, feeling rather like Bartholomew Cubbins in Dr. Seuss's story of *The Five Hundred Hats*. Each new version I heard was like the successive cocked hats Bartholomew Cubbins found on the stairs of the tower, one

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embellished with one jewel, the next augmented by another jewel, the next a jewel and a feather, then one with a jewel and two feathers, and so on. Yet I never heard a listener complain, "You're not telling it right!", except in jest. All the stories told 'the same' story.

How could this be, in what I had been led to believe was a highly 'conservative' culture? How could such diversity exist in a society which prized equality of individuals perhaps beyond all else? As an anthropologist, I knew Ju/'hoan culture's 'social technology' for getting along with each other contained many mechanisms for social levelling and the prevention of self-aggrandizement. How could I square this knowledge with the personal flamboyance I was seeing in storytelling?

!Unn/obe's shrug, as I said, provided my first insight into the answer. The complexity that bemused me was ordinary to her: it presented no problems whatsoever. Why, then, was I struggling so much with it? I began to think about the perspective from which I myself was trying to understand her tradition.

For one thing, I was literate, and she was not. Nor were her listeners, nor the other storytellers who told variants of the stories !Unn/obe was telling. I had gone out, after all, with the specified intent of studying a narrative tradition as completely oral as I could find in the world in the decade of the 1970s. Now that I had found one, I had no idea what to do with it.

Gradually I began to piece back together my academic reading about the nature of oral versus literate communication. Albert Lord's *The Singer of Tales*, Eric Havelock, Marshall McLuhan ... I remembered that literate people must in a real sense struggle to realise that where speech is both the norm and the model for all verbal communication, two messages may be regarded as 'the same' though they are rarely verbatim equivalents. This equivalence of message explains storytellers' insistence that they are faithfully "repeating" an old story when they are actually telling it in their own words. Each telling thus reflects the performance situation of the moment *and* participates in the timeless authority of tradition. Concentration on specific wording and phraseology *per se* is a phenomenon of alphabetic literacy which has long distorted scholars' understanding of communication in oral societies.

Looking at an oral tradition as a whole, I recalled, means detailed attention to the idiosyncrasies of its performed parts. I found that where !Unn/obe used the 'unsaid' in dialogue to stimulate imaginative appreciation, another storyteller might elaborate hyperbolic invective between warring characters, to great stylistic advantage. Yet both tales would convey the same indirect social lessons, provide a scaffolding of events for graphic portrayal of moral and

immoral behaviour, and in the end be catalogued by listeners and storytellers alike as 'the same' story though they were widely divergent in style, language, and dramatic detail.

The socially-shocking events referred to, for instance, in these excerpts regarding vengeance among in-laws are routine parts of their oral tradition for Ju/'hoan listeners. But their familiarity doesn't diminish their entertainment (or their indirectly instructive) value. The same is true for expletives and scatological references, which enliven both folktales and daily talk for the Ju/'hoansi but are subject to scrupulous social avoidances in actuality. (Ju/'hoan talk is vivid with humorous hyperbole, none of which would ever be carried out in deed. An example of a perfectly polite greeting between two old men cronies who hadn't seen each other in a long time might be, "Face like a dead spirit-face, go screw yourself!" Yet the personal space and quiet dignity of both parties would remain intact and even be enhanced.)

It seems that with this people of circumspect social behaviour, expanded expressiveness may flourish in opposite proportion. In the area of equality in the ownership of possessions, Ju/'hoansi are fierce levellers. Yet verbal agility is not subject to levelling mechanisms in the same way: it seems individuals may push their creativity in speech much further without risk of censure. As George Steiner has commented, "certain cultures expend on their vocabularies and syntax acquisitive energies and ostentations entirely lacking in their material lives" (1975:55).

Steiner's words are echoed by a character in Brian Friel's play *Translations*, who warns against the danger of linguistic colonisation: features of the Irish landscape were being renamed for English convenience. So too should we all be warned against the ultimate linguistic colonisation, that of a local oral tradition by the literate mind-set. A resistant oral tradition must continually challenge the literate urge to standardise, to fix in print for all time, to specify the right or original or 'authoritative' version of a tale or any sort of utterance. It must preserve its right to individual ostentation within its own culturally defined limits.

Ju/'hoan storytelling in the last several decades has provided just such a challenge to me and other researchers. I believe we are charged with the job of finding a way for the meaningful variability of a contemporary oral tradition to penetrate the consciousness of our world increasingly dominated by print- and electronic-media. One way to do this is to show the relationship of individual expressiveness within a storytelling tradition to individual life experiences of the storytellers.

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I would therefore like to explore !Unn/obe Morethlwa's narrative technique from the point of view of what I know of her life history. I shall also compare and contrast her story with the experiences and history of /Kunta Boo, whom I met much later when he was nearly sixty and I about forty-five. Living at a village and permanent natural waterhole at /Aotcha, Namibia, /Kunta told stories both informally in the everyday context of his family and friends and 'professionally' as an occasional storyteller-in-residence for the developing Ju/'hoan language curriculum after Namibian Independence in 1990. The times /Kunta and !Unn/obe shared with me conveniently bracket a period in which I feel I grew significantly in understanding Ju/'hoan tradition. In particular, I had a chance to expand my grasp of its intimate relationship with the lives of contemporary individuals of both genders.

One inspiration for me in this approach has been Julie Cruikshank's book, *Life Lived Like a Story* (1990), which demonstrates the interpenetration of stories with the lives of three Yukon elders. Cruikshank shows that ancient 'girls' story' and 'boys' story' themes invigorate the attempts of contemporary individuals to live worthy lives. Far from limiting the repertoire of these storytellers to outdated models from the past, however, one senses that oral tales by their very evanescence are always being renewed for the contemporary situation.

Reading this and other presentations of 'modern traditional' stories, I began to see that specific storytellers now, as in the past, have done cultural work appropriate to their times and crucial to the continuation of culture. What emerges from this kind of perspective is a humanised view of the past as ever-present grist for the mill of the future. This performative approach underscores the insight once articulated to me by my colleague, anthropologist Richard Lee: "'Once upon a time' is NOW".

In my own experience with Ju/'hoan storytellers like !Unn/obe and /Kunta, there is no question that the long ago is synonymous with the contemporary. (The same is true, of course, for the Australian Aboriginal 'Dreaming'.) Old stories are powerful not because they come from the past, but because they are being told in the present. They are told in the present by specific individuals with specific histories. In fact, there seems to be an essential relationship between the storytellers' life experiences and their aesthetic choices, which determines the dimensions of the stories' power and energy.

!Unn/obe, for instance, had been twice married, both times to rather eccentric Ju/'hoan men. She had a wry but resigned attitude toward the world of males, and kept up a gentle but firmly effective joking with her second

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husband, Kha//'an. She had lived half her life in skins in the bush, and half as a serf doing barely recompensed domestic labour. From her perspective at outdoor kitchens and washing lines behind the houses, she told me about early Boer ranchers who settled in Ghanzi. She had lived for a while on a mission station but had rejected the religious teaching in favour of her own healing religion.

When I met !Unn/obe in 1971 she was living in a grass hut in the bush again in the sixth decade of her life. She sustained herself as part of a socially traditional community by gathering wild foods and selling ostrich-eggshell beadwork to occasional tourists, who in those years and in that place numbered few more than two or three per year. Her people's isolation and hunting-gathering heritage were at that time increasingly under pressure, not only from white ranchers, but also black Tswana and Herero pastoralists, who wished to expand their cattle herds into the former Bushman foraging areas. (Though white ranchers depend on fencing to control their cattle, and pastoralists in general depend on herding practices, the effect on hunting-gathering people is the same. Their land is sequestered or ruined by trampling hooves, and their very food sources are threatened.)

!Unn/obe's perspective on changing times had been informed by a great deal of experience on the boundaries between her own and the incoming societies, both black and white. She had all the ingredients for trenchant political analysis. She was, in fact, the catalyst for my own political awakening, informing me shortly after we had met that what had "ruined" her people were four things brought into her remote area by outsiders: tobacco, sugar, alcohol, and coffee. "These things have turned us into slaves", she said matter-of-factly. In the long interview I did with her in 1971, she explained without rancour but with great clarity the process by which the contact with settlers where she grew up in the Ghanzi District, south of the Ju/'hoan area, gradually circumscribed her people's freedom:

> When the white people had filled up Ghanzi, we then saw for the first time the things which came with them. We saw for the first time engines to draw up water, and all the things that we had never seen until the white people came. The white people certainly have a lot of things!
>
> But when the first whites came, they had to pound up and eat what the black people ate. They used digging sticks like ours at the beginning. They collected food and ate it. In fact, I came to know *zan* roots [used to sour milk distinctively for churning butter] through the Boers. They spoke, and we dug *zan* roots for them and pounded them and laid them out to dry. Then we'd churn and churn and churn with them, receiving only black coffee to

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drink for doing this. Then we'd churn and churn some more, and the butter would come, and they'd put it in bowls, put it in bowls, put it in bowls, and then they'd sit and drink the buttermilk and distribute some to us also.

Another portion of the milk they would refuse that we churn, because they wanted us to put it into their coffee for them to drink. When the empty tins were full, the Boers were finished with this work. The milk spent the night here, and the butter spent the night there. The water engine would stop and make a sound like "ko-ko-ko" but the cattle still drank. We Ju/'hoansi drew and drew and drew water by hand. We cranked and cranked until the trough was full and the cattle could come and drink. If there was no engine — uh-uh! A Bushman would do the work! Bushmen worked hard! We, the red Bushmen, are the ones who did the work of that place, Ghanzi.

Women did the work of drawing water. Women took care of the cattle. Women took care of the calves. Women took care of the sheep. Women took care of the horses. Women took care of the donkeys.

The men worked cutting trees for poles and lumber and all kinds of wood uses. Men did this, and they also milked the cows. The women were slower about getting up in the mornings, because they had no warm clothes. The Boers for whom we worked at that time are no longer in Ghanzi, as we sit here now. Then the word came to us, the word of Seretse [Seretse Khama, first President of Botswana]. The word was "Ipelegeng" [self-reliance]. Seretse said to the Boers, "White people, treat your employees nicely and with respect." When that word came down, they ran off. They are no longer over there in Ghanzi. There are only different Boers there now.

The Tswanas said, "We're not chasing you away. We're just saying you should pay your employees regularly, so they can make a decent living." Some of them agreed, even if doing it defeated them. Some of them just packed up and left without asking any questions. Took their money and left. I'm telling you. The pain we had from them was just that they didn't pay us, and our heads were good enough to tell us this wasn't right.

/Kunta Boo, with whom I worked in Namibia from 1987 to 1993, is a respected psychic healer as well as a storyteller, and also a fine hunter. Despite his age and his atypically dumpy build, he thinks nothing of three-day hunts which cover great distances tracking an animal on foot in the heat. He is well used to all-night trance dances throughout which he may be vigorously active. He is a strikingly good rememberer of lore and linguistic facts, and acted as one of the major guides in his people's recent mapping of their traditional territories (*n!ores*) as the basis for land claims.

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As a person, /Kunta strikes one immediately as both extremely modest and as the possessor of unshakeable self-authority. He is centred by the spiritual and intellectual achievements of his life. The young people in his culture feel this centredness — no one who comes into contact with him fails to feel it.

Many of his special interests and abilities are reflected in the way /Kunta tells both his life story and the Ju/'hoan traditional tales. Themes of male life such as magical transformation through altered states of consciousness, the origins of psychic medical apparatus and powers, and the spiritual dimensions of hunting and territory are strongly etched in both kinds of stories he tells, as we see in the extract from a much longer story, below.

The extract is part of a hunting and trance-healing folktale — a 'boys' story' because it deals with themes of male initiation — which /Kunta has told in my hearing many times in the seven years I have known him. One version, collected by Patrick Dickens and transcribed from tape by G≠kao /Kaece as part of the vocabulary/curriculum work for the new Ju/'hoan education programme, contains the episode below.

Brief though it is, it is alive with topics which interest /Kunta, such as dealing with dangerous carnivores, using magical means to detect and overcome evil, human-animal spiritual communication, hunting and healing power, and right relationships among relatives and hunting partners. The protagonist, Big G≠kao, is helping his sons achieve the transformation to adulthood on their ritual hunt. During the hunt they have killed an eland and have then been killed in turn by lions, who are in conflict with them over hunted meat. The lions are here referred to by a respect term, "westerners", because they personify forces of evil, said to dwell in the west, the land of death where the sun goes down. Mr Tortoise and the Cotton Wool Bird are big G≠kao's helpers.

> Then Big G≠kao [the earthly incarnation of the great god during the past imaginary time] made some birds: a thrush, a sparrow-weaver, a grey loerie, and a grey lark. When he had finished, he said, "Thrush, you go and fly downwind and warn me of anything. Sparrow-weaver, you go and fly upwind. Grey Loerie, you stand here in the path. And Grey Lark, since you're a big-mouth, you stay on the south side and keep guard. I'm going to do something else now."
>
> G≠kao N!a'an [Big G≠kao] took the eland's head and put a spell on it. Then he hung it up in a tree and told the Cotton Wool Bird and Mr Tortoise that they should begin testing it. So they began to dance around it first in one direction and then the other. Big G≠kao told them, "You two go ahead and dance and I will dance behind you, and we'll see if the plan works." So they danced in front, and he danced behind them. The two of them

> passed under the eland's head, but when Big G≠kao was under it, he said "Fall down!" and the eland's head fell down and its horns sliced through the string of his loincloth and split open his pelvis. He picked up the eland's head and hung it up again.
>
> "That which it has done to me", he said, "will it not also do the same to another man?" So they started dancing again and, after a certain time, the eland's head fell down again, and again sliced through the string of his loincloth.
>
> Big G≠kao picked it up again and, addressing it, said, "I have finished checking you, but now a great dance is about to begin, and this time when you fall, you must fall like fire from the sky."
>
> Then he said to Mr Tortoise and the Cotton Wool Bird, "I have finished, and now we must just wait for the westerners. When they come, we'll start the dance. What I have done will help us later against those who will come to us. Now we are ready for the westerners."
>
> When the sun had gone down, the westerners were in the wind and the thrush gave warning. "What's this then?" it said. Big G≠kao said to Mr Tortoise and the Cotton Wool Bird, "It is as I said. It's the two of them over there standing in the wind ...."

In Ju/'hoan tradition, initiation for young men into adulthood involves ritual hunting, symbolic care of younger men by older men, learning to dance and enter a state of trance for healing, and amassing knowledge of animal behaviour, as well as establishment of the correct attitudes towards kinspeople. This story is quintessentially a story of boys' initiatory themes, the ways by which they establish social personhood. Big G≠kao as the older male figure takes the eland head (an eland is the most revered of the great meat animals) from the boys' ritual hunt and teaches them through dancing magic to protect themselves from carnivores.

He makes and uses the powers of specific birds to give warning of the approach of evil forces. He communicates directly in human speech with these birds and with his other animal helpers. He brings together the power needed to hunt effectively with that needed to trance and heal. And, most importantly, he transmits to the next generation of young men the knowledge of how to do these manly things for their society.

When /Kunta told me the story of his life, many of the same themes were emphasised. Here is part of the story which he told me in 1991 of how he first came to have the spiritual healing power, *n/om*:

> I came from !Xoma N/ai!'ua [a place called Baby Elephant Skull] in the rains. My old people, my mother and father, said, "Let's go over to this *n!ore* [hunting and gathering territory]". So I went with them. We travelled

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and lived at a place called //'Ang/'uma [Little Poke-it-in]. We left there and went to a place called !'Om!'usi [Porcupine Bones] ... Then they said we'd go north. We went and lived at Samangaigai ... we went there and danced. When the women sang we danced. The women liked me. They wanted to grab me in the dance circle and take me to their huts ... We were dancing *the Giraffe Dance ... I didn't know what to do. They said, "We want to* 'marry' you. We want to take you and keep you." ... I said, "No, I won't do that. I'm still young. I'm not thinking about women. If you say you want me, maybe it's my body you want." So I left.

So we lived and lived and one day went to a */ui* tree, and we walked around it looking for a duiker [small buck] to shoot. Then I became weak and didn't go hunting with the others ... I didn't hunt but lay in the shade — in fact I was sick. Sickness entered me. When we came back to the village I asked myself, "Why is my flesh not feeling good? Why do I feel sick?" So we went to sleep. The sun went down and I felt myself when the dawn broke and said, "Is this how I am? Am I just sick?" Then we said, "Let's go back home to our *n!ore*." I said, "If I feel this bad we should go back to our *n!ore* and let me die there."

So we did, but in fact it was not sickness, it was the death of *n/om* [the onset of spiritual medicine powers]. When we got here [back to their home *n!ore*, Nyae Nyae], two men (my relatives) came to me. They told me, "*Today if you're like this, today you're a n/omkxao* [owner of medicine]" ... So we came to ... ≠'Og!au [Clean White Mangetti Nut Grove] and lived there. When the rains came, it wasn't really rain but was these two men, who grabbed my arm and I was looking toward the east. Then I 'died'. They said, "Even though you've 'died' like this, you haven't died. You are a person who has been 'taken in hand' and hasn't died. You're a person who is learning."

...

I was sick and really hurt and thought I'd die ... My 'father', who washed me [ritually] in the bush, kept me there for a while and then I was 'alive' again ... Then I was in a Ju/'hoan house. They said they were going to put me into the sand to bury me. That's when I began to really wake up and live. My 'father' saw me and said, "This guy is alive. Don't let him see that pit over there...." Then I said, "That thing over there you have dug to bury me." And they said, "No, that's just what the earth surface is like there; it's not meant for you."

...

In the morning we left — I had *n/om*! In fact they had taught me. We went to another *n!ore*. My father and older brother went to the bush, and my father shot a kudu. My older brother shot a warthog. In the morning they told us about the animals they had shot. I wasn't right — my thoughts

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> were not like human thoughts. My thoughts instead went to the thoughts of "those beyond", the spirits. I didn't know what stories they were telling. In fact it was that the spirits had already given me *n/om* ....
>
> It wasn't *n/om* which had come from people's hands, but *n/om* of the spirits. The one they call !Xu — !Xu is G≠kao N!a'an [!Xu is another name for the great creative god who appears also in the folktales from "another time"] — he gave me *n/om*. The spirits took this spot in the middle of my head and cured it. They took my head hairs to the leaders of the gods. They saw them and said, "This is a good person, an owner of medicine. Teach him well so he can make his people live." Since then I've danced *n/om*.
>
> We Ju/'hoansi say that "Nonabe" [another name for the great god] helped me and I was fine. I've worked since then at my village. And the spirits help me. I've healed people. Nonabe is "the owner of work", "the owner of authority". His name is like G≠kao N!a'an, he's Nonabe, it's his respect name. You don't see him — he just works through voices. He's like the Government ... He stays inside a termite mound. It is the speech of the one inside the termite mound. His speech is not he. The speech itself is what is the owner of authority.

In both /Kunta's and !Unn/obe's stories, life elements like healing, hunting, gathering, mission experience, community customs, ethnic inequality, gender interactions, and politics are clearly visible. These combine to make their renditions of old tales, as well as their life stories, full of referential richness for their listeners. !Unn/obe, now deceased, specialised in the description of landscape, in pithy, wry conversation between characters, especially between males and females in agonistic relation, and in picturesque and suggestive euphemisms emphasising female power and occult strength. /Kunta, in contrast, uses extremely careful knowledge of natural species and phenomena to describe the real and imaginary landscapes of his stories. He dwells on themes of male power such as altered states of consciousness, cultural creativity, and the origins of magical items and forces, and many of his stories ruminate in detail on the intellectual as well as the physical activity involved in hunting large game animals with the 'low' technology of small, poisoned arrows. But both storytellers return time and again to the social disciplines of getting along in Ju/'hoan life — what works and doesn't work in small-group morality: the sharing ethic, circumspect behaviour, tolerance for others and their opinions. Just like Julie Cruikshank's storytellers, this woman and man are 'of their times' in how they tell their tales, yet their tales are tales 'of themselves' in a special sense.

Both !Unn/obe and /Kunta are placed in the matrix of a society whose respect for individual points of view allows for a flowering of expressive styles. This

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flowering itself has become characteristic of the tradition, and inseparable from it. The degree of communicative latitude not only allowed but expected of individuals turned out to be immensely greater than I imagined at the outset. I came gradually to suspect that social agreement as mediated orally is a much more complex enmeshment of many individual creative understandings of the world than I had ever dreamed.

It had been first !Unn/obe's answer to my question, and later observing how /Kunta lived his life in complete acceptance of his own idiosyncratic 'take' on reality, that crystallised my awareness of the vibrant link between culture and the persons in it. I also finally realised that printing, and all that it has entailed in the Western world-view in the centuries since it became widespread, can practically obliterate the variability that is the stuff of life-as-story. I learned in fact that print, with its message of replicability and controllability, had become the story of my own life as an academic — and even as a person.

The ramifications of this insight are immense. In later years I have begun to think hard about media politics and personal aesthetics, and to relate to them certain processes of global underdevelopment and mental colonisation. In these musings the unmanaged 'voice of the people', whether that of an indigenous minority like the Ju/'hoansi or of a minority of one like myself, has emerged as the signal that creative life was still present, that energy is still being generated for new use.

I took their enthusiasm in communications as my guide to the location of current energy in their tradition. I felt this to be true both of the Ju/'hoan expressive traditions I had made my life study and of the writing and speaking I did in my own culture. Present culture in Africa or anywhere seems to me to exist most vitally on its performed cutting edge, and this is as true for 'traditional' cultures as for the First World ones we imagine to be uniquely characterised by endless change.

I took this approach — of daring myself to look hard at the *present* — partly to overcome my own tendency to slip into romantic nostalgia about my own and others' pasts. I believe this tendency is a general one for many of us, often obscuring the reality of indigenous cultures. The tendency to romanticism can be seen as another product of the print culture and its educational consequences. We try to 'fix' other peoples in categories learnable by rote, and the result is that individuals become invisible. The ways they are transforming themselves become particularly invisible. Their great, current histories of themselves flatten into trite minor fictions.

How people relate to each other and work together within traditions has for a very long time held a complex dialogue with folklore, mythology, and other oral forms. Many African and other social systems have retained vital links to oral tradition far into the twentieth century. This of course has not been true all over the world: much of Europe, for instance, has been distanced for some centuries from its oral heritage by the overwhelming revolution of print and related media. But parts of Africa, Latin America, the far North, Asia, and elsewhere in the unevenly developing world have actually kept the connection. Seen as 'backwardness' by some, this connection is a source of strength and meaning, renewed creatively by individuals out of their deep, but still viable, past.

Different people, indeed, just have different minds. The whole challenge of social life is engagement of those different minds in agreements, understandings, and contracts. Just as aesthetics is inseparable from meaning, in an expressive tradition engagement of personal expressivity is inseparable from communal commitment to ideas, beliefs, and courses of social action. Coming to see these things in the context of Ju/'hoan storytelling has meant for me a surrender, simple in the end, to the power of individuals and what brings each one joy and satisfaction in uttering her own truth.

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